

Certified by Ring Light

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Essay

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Never in human history have so many people become experts in so many subjects so quickly. Apparently all it takes is a smartphone, a ring light, and the willingness to speak with absolute certainty about things you learned yesterday.

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Certified by Ring Light

A few weeks ago, I made the mistake of looking up a YouTube video on how to replace the cabin air filter in my truck.

This should have been a simple process. I wasn't rebuilding an engine. I wasn't attempting open-heart surgery in my garage. I just wanted to figure out which plastic panel to remove without accidentally snapping off three clips that would somehow cost forty-seven dollars apiece at the dealership.

Instead of finding a mechanic, I found an influencer.

Within seconds, this young man appeared on my screen standing in front of a ring light bright enough to signal aircraft. He had perfect hair, an expensive microphone clipped to his shirt, and the kind of enthusiasm normally reserved for lottery winners and people who discover buried treasure. Apparently changing an air filter had completely transformed his life. He wasn't simply replacing a maintenance item. He was embarking on a personal growth journey.

"This truck hack is absolutely insane," he announced.

It wasn't insane. It was an air filter.

The process involved opening a compartment and sliding out a dirty rectangle.

Yet somehow he delivered the entire presentation as though he had just uncovered evidence that aliens built the interstate highway system.

Then came the sponsor segment. Like clockwork, the excitement vanished.

One second he was bouncing around the garage like a Labrador retriever that had consumed three energy drinks and a family-sized bag of Skittles. The next second he was staring at cue cards and mumbling through an advertisement for a budgeting app with all the enthusiasm of a hostage reading a prepared statement.

Every influencer does this.

They are unbelievably excited about whatever they happen to be selling that day. A water bottle becomes life-changing. A backpack becomes revolutionary. A face cream becomes the greatest scientific breakthrough since penicillin. They can't stop talking about how obsessed they are with the product, how it changed everything, how they literally use it every single day.

Then they get to the actual sponsor.

"This episode is sponsored by..."

And suddenly they sound like they're reading the ingredients on a box of generic crackers.

For some reason, that always makes me laugh. Not because it's dishonest. Quite the opposite.

For three brief seconds, the performance stops. The influencer disappears. The salesperson accidentally becomes visible.

And every time I see it, I find myself wondering the same thing.

How exactly did we arrive at a point where millions of people take advice from individuals who aren't actually experts in anything?

To be fair, I'm not talking about people sharing their experiences. There's nothing wrong with that. Human beings have always learned from one another. We learned from parents, grandparents, neighbors, teachers, coaches, coworkers, and occasionally from the strange guy at the hardware store who somehow knew the answer to every question that had ever been asked.

That isn't new.

What's new is the rise of a professional class of people whose primary qualification appears to be their ability to speak confidently into a camera.

Need skincare advice? They've got it.

Need investment advice? They've got that too.

Need relationship advice? Absolutely.

Need parenting advice? No problem.

Need career guidance? Fitness guidance? Medical guidance? Home ownership guidance? Retirement guidance? Spiritual guidance? Dog training guidance?

Apparently all of these skills are acquired shortly after purchasing a ring light.

I don't know when confidence became a substitute for expertise, but somewhere along the way it definitely happened.

Growing up in the 1980s and 1990s, we certainly had know-it-alls. Every town had one. Usually several. They were the guys who had an opinion about everything. Politics. Sports. Cars. Foreign policy. Tax law. Child psychology. Weather patterns. Agricultural subsidies. They knew it all.

The difference was that back then they could only annoy the people within driving distance.

You'd run into them at Little League games or church picnics or standing near the coffee station at work. They'd explain why every politician was incompetent, every coach was overrated, and every major world problem could be solved if people would simply listen to them for five uninterrupted minutes.

Then you'd find an excuse to leave. Today those same people get followers.

Technology didn't create know-it-alls. Technology simply industrialized them.

What's fascinating is how quickly we started confusing popularity with competence. The moment somebody accumulates enough followers, enough subscribers, enough likes, enough comments, our brains begin making assumptions. Surely this person must know something. Why else would so many people listen?

The answer, unfortunately, is because so many people are already listening.

Popularity has become its own credential.

The strange thing is that actual experts usually don't sound anything like influencers. Real experts tend to be frustratingly cautious. They've spent enough years learning about a subject to understand how complicated it actually is.

Ask a doctor a question and you often hear phrases like, "It depends." Ask an engineer and you'll hear, "There are several factors involved." Ask an attorney and they'll spend twenty minutes explaining why there isn't a simple answer. Ask an influencer and you'll hear, "Here's what nobody wants you to know." One of those answers sounds exciting. The other one sounds like knowledge.

The more I've watched this trend develop, the more I've become convinced that genuine expertise and social media success often reward completely opposite behaviors. Expertise requires humility. Expertise requires admitting uncertainty. Expertise requires acknowledging complexity.

Social media rewards certainty. It rewards simplicity. It rewards people who can compress complicated subjects into thirty-second videos accompanied by dramatic music and oversized captions.

If a cardiologist says, "The answer is complicated," most people scroll past.

If somebody with perfect lighting says, "Doctors hate this one weird trick," millions of people stop and watch. That's not because we're stupid. It's because we're human.

Human beings have always preferred simple answers over complicated ones. We like certainty. We like shortcuts. We like feeling as though we have insider knowledge that other people somehow missed. Social media simply discovered a way to package those instincts into a business model.

What worries me is not that young people become influencers.

Young people have always believed they know more than they actually do. That's not a character flaw. That's youth. Most of us were exactly the same way.

The older I get, the more I realize how little I knew when I thought I knew everything. At eighteen, I was pretty sure I had life figured out. At twenty-five, I was certain of it. At forty, I wasn't so sure.

Now I'm at the age where I occasionally walk into a room and forget why I entered it, only to stand there staring at a wall until my brain reconnects to the network. Somehow, despite decades of education, work experience, parenting, mistakes, successes, failures, and enough embarrassing moments to fill several volumes, I feel less certain about many things than I did when I graduated high school.

That isn't because I've become less intelligent. It's because reality has had more opportunities to correct me. That's how wisdom usually works. Life hands out humility whether you order it or not.

The problem with influencer culture is that it often allows people to skip that entire process. Instead of spending years learning something and eventually teaching it, many people begin teaching immediately and hope the learning part catches up later.

Sometimes it does. Often it doesn't.

Meanwhile millions of viewers watch someone who has never managed a business explain entrepreneurship, someone who has never raised children explain parenting, someone who has never owned a home explain real estate, and someone who has never lived independently explain how life works.

The most impressive accomplishment in many cases is not expertise. It's confidence. I suppose that's the part I find most amusing.

When I was younger, confidence was usually earned through experience. You became confident because you'd done something successfully over and over again. You knew how to handle a situation because you'd already survived similar situations.

Today confidence sometimes appears to arrive first. Experience is optional.

It's almost as if we've collectively decided that talking about something and doing something are roughly equivalent activities. They aren't.

I've watched enough home improvement videos to understand that I am not a contractor. I've watched enough football to know that I am not an NFL coach. I've eaten enough food to understand that I am not a chef. There are entire corners of the internet populated by people who seem unable to recognize these distinctions. But before we blame influencers for everything, we should probably be honest about our role in this arrangement.

At the end of the day, influencers didn't create themselves. We created them. The audience is half of the equation. Every view, every click, every share, every comment is a tiny vote. We claim to value expertise, yet we routinely reward entertainment. We claim to value knowledge, yet we often prefer confidence. We claim to want truth, yet we're frequently attracted to certainty even when certainty has no business existing.

The market is simply responding.

If videos titled "A Balanced Discussion of Complex Economic Factors" generated fifty million views, that's what people would make.

Instead, we get videos called "Five Things They Don't Want You To Know." Apparently "they" are very busy. "They" don't want us to know anything. "They" seem to spend all day hiding information from influencers who somehow uncover these secrets between brand partnerships and affiliate marketing opportunities.

The older I get, the funnier that becomes. But beneath the humor sits a more serious concern.

A society that stops respecting expertise eventually stops respecting experience. When experience loses value, wisdom loses value. When wisdom loses value, every generation becomes convinced it is discovering truths that previous generations somehow missed.

Then reality arrives. Reality always arrives. The mortgage payment arrives. The difficult marriage arrives. The struggling child arrives. The health scare arrives. The business failure arrives. The layoff arrives. The aging parent arrives. And suddenly many of the simple answers stop looking so simple.

That's when experience begins teaching lessons that social media can't.

That's when people discover that most meaningful parts of life are complicated, messy, emotional, and resistant to shortcuts.

The irony is that the people who genuinely know something are often the least interested in presenting themselves as universal experts. They understand the limits of their knowledge. They understand context. They understand exceptions. They understand that human beings are not assembly instructions.

They've earned their caution.

Meanwhile the internet keeps handing microphones to people who haven't yet earned much of anything except attention.

Maybe that's where things are at right now. Maybe we're living through an era where visibility carries more weight than wisdom and confidence carries more weight than experience. History has gone through stranger phases. Lord knows we survived pet rocks, New Coke, reality television, and cargo shorts wide enough to shelter a family of four.

We'll survive influencers too. I just hope that somewhere along the way we remember that being seen and being knowledgeable are not the same thing.

A camera can amplify expertise. It can also amplify nonsense. The camera doesn't know the difference.

That's still our job.